Q+A

IN SHIVA HE TRUSTS

At 91, Dr Karan Singh is equally devoted to politics and scholarship, but editing the recently released *Shiva: Lord of the Cosmic Dance* was for him an expression of a more personal piety

Q. Compared to other gods and goddesses, is Shiva an easier deity to theorise?
In some ways, he was more difficult to theorise. Other gods fitted neatly into the Vedic pantheon, but Shiva was always the outsider. The way he dressed, smoked, ate—was totally outside, totally beyond the normal. In the end, I think what led to him being accepted is the fact that he was all-encompassing.

Q. Given our strong tradition of Shaivism, isn't it odd that we do so little for those on the margins?
Yes, that's a national weakness. We have never had enough empathy for the backward. It doesn't matter if for the past 75 years we have tried to abolish poverty, Covid has pushed many crores back into the lower income status. Even though this might have little to do with Shiva, he represents them too.

Q. So, in a world that is being ravaged by Covid and war, how relevant is Shiva, the God of Death?
Shiva has two Tandavas. First is Ananda Tandava, which sees him dancing in bliss and bringing the world into being. His Vinasha Tandava, on the other hand, destroys everything. A nuclear war, for instance, could do that. So, all we can do is to pray to him and say, "Please never shoot us with that arrow you hold".

Q. Finally, how much of a role should religion play in politics, do you think?
Rather, we must ask how much of a part is it already playing. I like to find my answers in all-encompassing Vedantic philosophy. There's no exclusion there.

—with Shreevatsa Nevatia



RAJWANT RAWAT